

Interviewer: So, good day. Thank you again for participating in this interview as mentioned to you before, we want to know more about your views on romantic relationships and we believe your experience and perspective would bring much to the project. So, before we begin, is it alright if you record this interview? We will only use it for transcription, note-taking.

Speaker: Yes. Yes.

Interviewer: So, how old are you?

Speaker: I'm [50-55].

Interviewer: How long have you been together with your partner?

Speaker: We've been married [20-25] years, going [20-25]. But we've known each other since [Year]. So I guess it's [30-35] years. So, we've known each other for [30-35] years? Wait hold on, we've known each other for, since [Year], we've known each other. So, basically at [20-25] plus [20-25], [40-45]. We've known each other for [40-45] years. Did I have my math correct? Oh, no, sorry. [30-35] years.

Interviewer: [30-35] years. And then you've been married for [20-25]?

Speaker: We've been married for [20-25].

Interviewer: [20-25] years. Wow. So, do you have children?

Speaker: Yes, we have [1-5] children. We're adoptive parents. In the process of adopting [1-5] children. First one is [name] at [6-10] years old and then the second one is [name] at [6-10] years old.

Interviewer: So, who lives in the household?

Speaker: So, it's the [1-5] of us together with our [household members], [Name] and [Name], and sometimes [Name], kapag nag face-to-face. And also the daughter of [Name], [Name], also stays with us so, she acts like a big sister to the kids and also helps out in the house.

Interviewer: So, how would you like us to, I mean, how would you like us to address your partner?

Speaker: Oh, [Partner's Name], just call her [Partner's Name].

Interviewer: Okay. Can you tell me about your love story?

[Portion Redacted]

Interviewer: So how would you compare the quality of your relationship compared to that of your friends' relationship?

Speaker: Hard to, it's hard to, because I'm not really privy to the relationships of my friends. I mean, I only know, I mean I don't live with them 24/7. So I, very hard, so I would say with [Partner's Name] kasi, I think our foundation is that we were friends. Well we started off as crushes, mutual crushes and finally we were dating and then eventually became friends and then, hard to, I guess make a comparison with other friends. I have friends who are very affectionate, always together, and then there are those who are not really that affectionate to each other, in fact sometimes throwing affectionate insults to each other but they somehow get along and it's like kalinging brutal, so to speak. Maybe [Partner's Name], I guess, it's a little bit of both. I mean sometimes, maybe, maybe we're kind of in between. We're neither

clingy and always together and hopelessly sweet couple but neither are we, we also respect each other and neither are we like throwing insults to each other, like affectionate insults to each other parang kalinging brutal. We're kind of like that and you know, and through the years because things people change and she has changed whereas before she kind of like going out a lot and traveling. Now, she really prefers staying home and being quiet. So if there's any gift I would give her it's to enhance that quiet mood she has if I can somehow make things quiet for her, let's say we can get away in a [location] that's quiet or maybe in a [location]. So she doesn't, she's not so much in flowers, she's not so much in chocolates, that stuff and she, she would prefer that I bought her, for example, a box of kimchi or let's say, I know something from those squid flakes. She prefers something that she really likes to eat or use than the usual flowers.

Speaker: So in terms of expressing ourselves to each other, it's really more, it's more conversation. To her, it's not so much the holding hands or even physical intimacy. She's more "can you talk to me?" "be present" and not be on your phone parang that's the biggest gift I can give her is I'm not on my phone. So yeah that's sort of like how we express our love for each other and siya naman, she shows hers by being almost involved in almost anything like even my haircut or the clothes I wear she would tell me so I guess she cares about how I look, how I present myself to the public and how I communicate. She's always very involved. She just likes being together always and so ayun yung ano. So ako, with my busy schedule, that's the best gift I can give, just to be present.

Interviewer: So it's really time.

Speaker: Time, yeah.

Interviewer: So can I also ask how many romantic partners you've had in the past?

Speaker: Woah! Ah, when, girlfriends I've had [1-5]. Officially [1-5] girlfriends. Yeah, that spans from when I was, I guess [11-15] to when I'm [30-35]. But there were some couple, couple of girls, I guess you could call it that we were romantically linked or romantically together but you weren't officially a boyfriend-girlfriend.

Interviewer: Parang M.U.?

Speaker: Yeah, because of baby circumstance, like for example, there were a couple, I mean [school] and I couldn't commit to a boyfriend-girlfriend relationship and I also had no money because I was a student so there were those na parang, who I had, I guess an affection, romantic, and maybe romantic but couldn't really commit.

Interviewer: Now, how would you compare the quality of your relationship compared to your previous relationship?

Speaker: Hard to describe that, hard to compare it kasi after [20-25] years of marriage there's so much intimacy, not just physical but knowledge of each other and you get to live with each other and you kind of see each other's works and so hard eh. I've never really lived with anyone, the others. So very hard to compare so I can't make a comparison. Maybe if I lived in with one of them, I could maybe make a comparison but I can't compare [Partner's Name] with anyone else because in terms of, we've been together for [20-25] years as a married couple, and I've never had a chance to be together like that as living together with other ano, so hard to do, hard to ano and each of them are different. I don't know if

I am answering your question but siguro, in this relationship, there's a lot more demand, but there's a lot more I guess transparency or need for transparency. There's a lot more need for transparency. Whereas before, in boyfriend-girlfriend, we can still, well there's some things that are not covered or not discussed or talked about but say money issues wasn't an issue, bedtime habits were not discussed or kids were not discussed but with [Partner's Name] those are discussed, financial matters, bedroom antics or bedroom habits or just how, home habits and obviously the kids. So that's the main difference. I never, with my other girlfriend, I never had to talk about those things and you know, kami naman, we still, especially with me and I'm still very vocal with her and tell her I love her. Well, siya, she's sometimes a little bit, I guess embarrassed na rin to say it but I know that she does. She always tells me. I want you to be here, if you can you work from home. So I know that she wants me around also to help her with the kids.

Speaker: And her care is really just making sure, she's like a girl scout that parang everything must be available. If it was just me, I probably just have [1-5] bottle of alcohol but she has [20-25]. Mga ganon. If it was just me, I probably have [1-5] rolls of toilet paper but she has [96-100], she has [46-50] parang she's like a girl scout, she's always preparing and that's her, that's her way of making sure that everything I need, I may need is around. So she'll tell [Name] what to cook. That's pretty much I guess the difference, you know, from previous relationships.

Interviewer: Okay. So for you what makes a relationship high quality?

Speaker: Constant communication, transparency, being open, being an open book and not really hiding anything in the sense na, of course, there are some things that are private, but generally just being transparent and being upfront and being sometimes brutally frank and I think with us, particular leaders, a need for not just be present na parang "thinking of you" but there's a need for a physical presence because we have [1-5] adopted kids who sometimes attachment issues and maybe abandonment fears so we take, not like the usual parents, their biological parents, but to me kasi we need to do, go an extra mile to assure these kids that we're here, we're not going to leave you, we're okay and so it's like we kind of like, as a partner, me and [Partner's Name], we try to make sure of that and we try to hold each other accountable na parang "oh, you have to be like this, you have to ano." It's a little bit harder for me because obviously I need to do meetings and business but that doesn't mean that, that doesn't mean that everything should fall on her so there's a number of things that I do for the kids to make sure that they're okay.

Speaker: So to answer your question, I think your question is that what is the most biggest, important thing to keep that ano is I think constant communication and constant reassurance that I'm here and yun nga, just being focused and not being distracted in the world. It's something that I'm struggling with because this world offers a lot of distractions. Not just other way of it or whatever but it's more text messages or [Social Media] groups or parang emails constantly coming in. It takes away your attention so I think what's most important is to be able to, to do that, to be able to be present. Yung attention mo is really focused on them and you show it. You show it so it's balancing.

Interviewer: What about low quality? What makes your relationship low quality?

Speaker: Well, low quality is basically no communication, indifference, you don't really care about what the other person's feeling. I mean, there are some people, there are some couples I know that they're really just living with each other, living with each other but don't really care like parang "bahala ka sa

buhay mo” type, “I don't really care if you're going home late or whatever just, you know, just come home here and, and provide” diba and yung ano naman yung husband, “I don't really care, oh sige mag Mahjong ka if you want” and then parang I live my life, you live your life and then at the end of the day we are housemates and we're together in raising the kids. So for me, that's kind of low quality, parang you're almost like, parang nagkataon na you're living lang together so the lack of communication and indifference that's, that's what makes it low quality.

Interviewer: Okay. So for you what are the most, well you sort of answered it a while ago, but what are the most important things in a relationship and why do you say so?

Speaker: One is that you should, yun nga, communication and enhance, an enhance that, is that causing communication of, I guess reassurance, because if you communicate lang, you're just whining or complaining about the other and that's not, that's not good communication. I'm talking about good communication and effective communication for it and sharing, and sharing both good and bad, and I think obviously you need to have a spiritual center that both, you are both believers of God and share a little bit of fear, fear of God and also a focus that, that you know that when you're home, your biggest role is being played at home. I mean I can be president of a company or I can be a business partner here or director here but the most important, it's realizing that your biggest role, the most important role is the one that you play in the house. So those are key important things, so basically, not just communication, constant good communication, both negative and positive and hindi lang puro negative and just being, and realizing this is the most important thing that you need to do and of course, being the example three important things and need to respect those.

Interviewer: So for you, what is love?

Speaker: For me, love is simple. It is something, it is all about forgetting yourself and only thinking of the others, the other. So for me that's, if you go biblically love is patient, is kind, love is never angry, love is you know all of those. So that's, that's what love is. It's a kind of a selfless, parang it's kind a mode of selflessness and always thinking of the other party even if you feel you're right or even if you feel that you didn't do anything wrong the other person feels bad over something that you may have said or something that you may have done. It's realizing to say sorry so I don't believe in the same love means that you don't have to say sorry there's a song like that love doesn't mean, love means that you don't have to say sorry but I don't believe in that, in fact, you have to constantly be saying sorry and apologize and of course we're never perfect and even in our best intentions, you can hurt the other party. So I think love is all about not thinking of yourself and always thinking of the other, other party and their benefit and how they can taken care of.

Interviewer: So how important is love in a relationship?

Speaker: It's basically the most important ingredient, I mean without it you don't stand a chance. ‘Yun na lang. So, that's how important it is. It's like water that nourishes a tree when treating bare food. Without water, it's just going to die so love is that water. To self-giving, it's a life-giving thing. Love is the one thing that science cannot explain because if you think about it animal world or in nature, diba? Turning the other cheek or another it's all about eye for an eye it's really all I'm going to get whatever I can get make sure that the other person doesn't get it, it's unselfish. But love in the animal world it's like that, they fight each other, but of course, there's a little bit of nurturing by the moms and everything

but, you know, but generally it makes us human—it's love—and it's the one thing that science can't explain. Sure to try to explain it may be biochemically hard to explain something.

Interviewer: So, how do you know that your partner loves you?

Speaker: Well, she hasn't left me so, and also by her constant reminder that she wants me around all the time and that she really prefers me being here. She always tells me that daddy I really need you to focus and attention to me and my family. So that constant expression of the need for me to be with them, not just physically, but mentally. I can be physically here but I'm in something. So yeah, so that's, that's her basically she's making sure that everything in the household is somewhat important out of we're taken care of, me and the kids. Yeah, she's not, to begin with, she's always not been physically affectionate at the time but you can tell. I mean there are moments that when you go that, daddy stay, stay here. Daddy can you stay with me naman especially if I work from home. She wants me to stay, to stay with her and be inside there, so don't throw the small gestures but that doesn't have to be parang always holding hands, always hugging, just wanting to be together and being silent together, just being with each other.

Interviewer: So, what would you say are the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker: Yeah the challenges are sometimes when the other party doesn't realize that the other person is already getting hurt or getting affected by things that you are doing that you think is okay but it's throwing away my attention from them. It can be as simple as watching [Social Media] videos or [Social Media] videos, rather than, and these are just kind of useless random content when you could be spending time with her and talking with her and kids. It's as simple as that. Nagkaka-problems when, when there's a certain level of expectation in terms of your focus and your attention that you're giving to the family and it falls short of what is expected and that's when or also not being forthright, hiding things that you should tell her you know. Those are the things that come to mind.

Interviewer: Okay, so, how do you handle these challenges?

Speaker: Again it's, the best way is to communicate and communicate face-to-face. With technology kasi minsan it's through texts. It's always important to face-to-face and to sit down and trash out all the issues and all the pains and all the hurts and be upfront in how you feel and at the same time not being too defensive on your position and always be ready to eat some humble pie and apologize even if you don't think that you did anything wrong kasi if you did something that the other person is hurt.

Interviewer: So, aside from communication, what are the other ways that you maintain your relationship?

Speaker: Apart from communication, we spend time to go out on trips, we enjoy activities together, we pray together, ganon. So those are, apart from communication ah, and just, we like to think of other things that doesn't involve communication but yeah, we pray together, we go on vacations together, we eat together in restaurants or ganon. Just do things together because at the end of the day you do all your work and then you go home to family so that you'll be able to do things and sleep together and just talk about the day together.

Interviewer: So, would you say the relationship is good for you and why?

Speaker: Well simple, the relationship is good for me because it's, they're family, she's family but it has challenges obviously but challenges can make it stronger, can make the relationship stronger so sometimes it can be draining but at the same time, so is exercise. Exercise is draining. So I think that whatever pain or struggles and challenges you have in the relationship it's ultimately good unless it becomes extremely toxic at the point na you're no longer, you're no longer able to be what you're supposed to be. So yes it's good but obviously when both parties are already sad and miserable that's when, that's when you say it's not great but basically the fact that we were still constantly talking and we were always looking for ways to enhance the relationship and solve our issues. It's great.

Interviewer: So, did the relationship change you and in what way?

Speaker: Yeah. Kasi, when you, you are two people and you become one and there are some things you would have to adjust so one thing is that you don't, I don't think of myself first. In the relationship when, that's what it does don't think of yourself first. For example, if I score a big deal and I have money and the first thing that enters my mind is what can I give to them and I don't think of yourself so much. In fact, after that, when that makes you, someone once asked me what would make you happy, I said, "oh when I see my wife happy and my kids happy." "no no no, what would make you happy, kasi that's you being happy because other people are happy but what would make you happy?" So I said, "peace on earth and again peace with my family?" and but family na naman. I can't think of anything like my family or with a [Car Brand] make me happy or an [Car Brand] no eh it doesn't. I know it will not make me happy, it'll be nice, it'll be nice to have that's something that I'm staying up at night for so, so yeah, so I, I think that's, that's the answer there. What has changed is that I, you don't think of myself so much. Everything, everything I do, say, or think has something to do with the family and you're not thinking of your own self, gratification, something interesting.

Interviewer: What about your partner? Did she change during the relationship?

Speaker: Yeah, like I said she was more sociable before but now because with family she's in less, less desire to go out and be sociable and everything is focused on raising the kids and being a family. So yeah, it's just changed I guess she's less sociable and less, less need for going out there and getting affirmation from friends but she's everything's focused on the kids.

Interviewer: So, do you feel safe in the relationship?

Speaker: Yes, yes.

Interviewer: So relationship safety is notion of being able to open up to your partner about your experiences, thoughts, identity without fear of judgment or reprisal.

Speaker: There are some things that I will share obviously there's a sense of fear that she might not like it like that "Oh I have a dinner party, dinner event tomorrow" and I know that she will not like it. So I don't know if, I don't know if that necessarily means, and the fact that I know that she will not like it I don't know if that means I feel necessarily unsafe. So it's, siguro if I may rephrase the question...

Interviewer: Or expectation that other will offer comfort in caring in times of danger or distress.

Speaker: We're always going to have each other's back. So we're just, I think ultimately we know naman we have each other's back. Whatever problems we went through, we somehow found a way to resolve it so yeah I feel there's a certain sense of safety we somehow go back to, go back to being us, she and I

even if we sometimes have problems, we always go back to us and so my sense of safety is that when we are not fighting and we're at peace I feel at peace and safe. So I don't know if that makes sense but yeah there's a sense but obviously sometimes there are some things that I have to share to her like for example I have to go to a board meeting at [City] and it's going to take a few days, I know it will upset her so it's I have a sense of, sometimes you know, reluctance.

Interviewer: So if I'm going to ask you naman, this one, "My partner usually really listens to me." In a scale of 1 to 9, what will you answer?

Speaker: She usually really listens to me. I have a feeling that she will answer mababa but actually she listens to me but sometimes misses out on things so I, she listens to me but sometimes she misses out on things but she always listens to me, so I'll give her, maybe 8, but sometimes she misses out on things when I tell her, but generally she's a good listener.

Interviewer: Okay, so what about this one, "My partner usually is responsive to my needs."

Speaker: This is a dangerous ano ah, this is dangerous for me. I would say maybe 6?

Interviewer: So why 6?

Speaker: Because sometimes my needs are in contrast to her needs. For example, I have to go to somewhere but she needs me, so she...

Interviewer: Pag nag conflict?

Speaker: Pag nag coconflict, yeah.

Interviewer: What about this one, "How satisfied are you with your relationship from completely satisfied to completely dissatisfied?"

Speaker: Well, I have to say, nothing's perfect so it cannot be completely satisfied but I have to say as long as the relationship is there, I have to be very satisfied. If only somewhat satisfied then it's pointless to have them. So I put myself very satisfied but that doesn't mean I'm always happy.

Interviewer: But in general?

Speaker: In general, I think we are able to work this out.

Interviewer: What about this one, so, "How would you rate your satisfaction with your relationship in a scale of 1 to 10?"

Speaker: Yeah, I would say maybe eight. Very satisfied.

Interviewer: What about this one, if you are... pag may negative...

Interviewer: Are you gonna go na?

Speaker: How long pa?

Interviewer: Actually we're near na, okay, we have about one to... Yeah, just one question pala.

Speaker: One question left? Okay

Interviewer: But a sensitive one at that it's about sex, okay? If you don't mind, if I ask, and feel free to say if this is too sensitive for you to share but I also want to know more about your physical intimacy as a couple. These days, how often do you have sex?

Speaker: I would say maybe, lately not very much, but in general, I have to ano, I have to say sometimes, there will be, there will be moments, there will be a month it's quite often, there will be months that it's dry so I'll, I'll average it maybe. So if I average it out, twice a month if you average it out. So there are months that it's quite, quite well; there are months that it's dry.

Interviewer: How satisfied naman are you with your sex life and why do you say so?

Speaker: Are you going to, you're going to interview [Partner's Name] with this? I don't know...

Interviewer: I sent her the question.

Speaker: She said yes?

Interviewer: Yeah, but I mean these are confidential naman with your interviews.

Speaker: I would say, I get very satisfied you never completely satisfied especially at our age. It's not the same as when we were [gibberish]. A lot of it is based on, I mean the mood and we feel each other out but I would say considering, I get satisfied—middle. Hard to, hard to ano eh. We're not in the same place eh. Men are different than women. At some point men, you know can have babies and still have I guess the urge even in their [70-75]s but she was just going to have a baby at [80-85] with a girl who's [26-30] you know what I mean? So I would say there's maybe some frustration on my part but I won't say that I'm not satisfied. It could be better. So I would say maybe middle.

Interviewer: So, the last question is you said 8 with “How satisfied are you with your relationship?” The last question is “Why did you say 8?”

Speaker: Because, well one is not, not perfect and if I say I'm completely not satisfied parang the question begs itself why am I even here? So I have to have a certain level of positive satisfaction. I mean it's not, it's not perfect maybe if you asked me last week, I probably will have said 2 you know, but, but though like we work it, we work it out and I think you know naman [Partner's Name] was not pleased with me going to my board meeting/trip. She's just never happy with those things that I have to be and it's always a conflict though but now that we've resolved it or at least we're talking now, so I'm a little bit you know I'm a bit more satisfied now that we are somehow able to work.

Interviewer: Now you're feeling the relationship again is there

Speaker: But if you asked me over the weekend I probably would have said one because I knew we were not you know in good, good time but now we're talking parang it will be a test for us after what we went through this weekend, once we get over it and I was telling her nga let's go on a vacation and if you ask us what we're doing at the vacation we'll probably both will probably be scoring high but it depends on the state, the current state you know. There are days that you want to leave but the fact that we're talking and the fact that parang after that difficult week, we are still talking and somehow we're making progress. I think I'm satisfied with the fact that we are able to resolve or at least we can somehow try to resolve.

Interviewer: Okay so I'm not gonna summarize because I know you're rushing, but is there anything you'd like to add?

Speaker: It's never, okay, marriage is never what it's painted out to be, and people sometimes "oh I'm already married" "at [Location] every after." No it's, it's a struggle every day, it's difficult, painful but I equate it to working on the gym, it's painful, it's difficult it's hard but I still want to do it because I know at the end of the day, the end result is that I will be happy going through the pain. I notice a better result if I go through the pain rather than if I don't go through the pain. If I don't go to the pain and I just eat-eat, same with marriage, you go through the pain, it's hard, it's difficult to different struggles but at the end of the day you look back, wow yeah I feel all the pain but it's satisfying. That's why I say very satisfying because despite the pain and suffering, you are still together and you're still together, it's very satisfying you know that you're somehow able to weather the storm. Sometimes prayer is a struggle, you know you go to mass or worship sometimes it's a struggle, you're not in the mood or whatever, and sometimes painful, you get distracted but after you, after you go to worship you feel good. So not everything is sweet roses and butterflies marriage is a constant battle, a constant struggle but at the same time there are fun moments to it. Just like in workout, there are fun exercises to like so there's fun also there but mostly it's pain. No pain, no gain. So I feel I'm satisfied now because despite the pain that we go through, not agreeing on a lot of things, the kids... At the end of the day, you know we're still together and that's the, its choice and I know that I'm satisfied because when we're not at peace, when we're in the same, fighting, and physically separated, I feel miserable. That's the basis that I'm satisfied because there's no other place.

Interviewer: It's not like when you're not okay parang, "ah this is good riddance."

Speaker: Yeah yeah yeah

Speaker: When we're not okay I say that I'll be happier, I'll be happier without this but when it dawns on me, I'm not happy, I miss her, I miss the kids even if we're fighting because I go through a lot eh. I think that's, I'm not gonna support fraternity brothers or fraternities or hazing but I think one of the reasons why close ang mga frat brothers is because they go through pain together. I'm not condoning it but there is something like the [game] championship, the reason why ang lakas ng bond ng players after they win, because they went through the hardships together. in bond of soldiers in [Event] as they fight and then they go home with bonding nights so strong as they went through.

Interviewer: They've seen each other at they're not what their worst or good state.

Speaker: So I think you need that, you need that in any relationship. That's the reason why I think our lord suffered and died so he showed this is love. Love is about self-sacrifice not with him himself.

Interviewer: Okay so last, we want to be just ethically transparent as possible. So there are two options on how we'll be handling your data, so we want to know which one you are most comfortable with. So option one is that the transcript portions can be shared, none of which can be identified to you, so the de-identified transcript can also be read by other researchers.

Interviewer: So option two, if you were a bolder, another option is that the whole transcript can be shared but removed of sensitive and overly identifying details so it will still be anonymized. Although in this option there's a very minimal chance of someone who knows you well, if they read the research report can piece together the details in the transcript and narrow down who among their colleagues

they believe it is. Although again, no sensitive information will be shared. So of the two options, which are...

Speaker: The first option is, so there's more... The first option is more...

Interviewer: We'll redact your name, where you work if you've mentioned it in the...

Speaker: The second one?

Interviewer: Everything will be shared. Your name but we will remove also identifying details like if you mentioned your work or anything but if you didn't naman...

Speaker: Yeah, I'd rather the first one. I can mention my age or my, but maybe not age and the reason being is that I was a public, I mean there was a time I was a [occupation] and for people, I think people know me more than I realize sometimes I go to the [location], "huy kayo po yung nasa [company] dati? So I'd rather it's you know...

Interviewer: Okay, so thank you so much for participating in this study. I would like you to know that this is also being done in the Philippines, Brazil, Netherlands, France, and the US for this study to be successful and is there any person that you can recommend for us to be a nominate...